director of major corporations in a country which is no longer repudiated by its neighbours. South Africa has emerged as the darling of the IMF and the World Bank. Its leaders spout progressive rhetoric at the UN, while acting as trustworthy partners for the United States.[17] But this neoliberal turn has torn South Africa apart. Since 1996, the combination of privatisation and trade liberalisation, with the removal of restrictions on the movement of people, generated a chaotic urbanisation which has only deepened social polarisation.[18] Unemployment has doubled and now affects 36% of the population. Inequality ranks at the top of the world index (Gini coefficient of 0.73). Disasters in the provision of water, precariousness of housing, and the degradation of education are major problems. Wages have stagnated alongside the growth of employment agencies which mediate the labour supply. And hidden forms of servitude persist on the 87% of land which is monopolised by white farmers.

The extreme modalities of combined and uneven development which generated apartheid in the first place have not disappeared. That system joined capitalist and pre-capitalist forms together by means of exceptional extra-economic methods. The temporary and migrant labour that connected the modern sectors to the backward sectors of the economy has now been remoulded and is recreating the old fractures.[19] South Africa is also enduring the erosion of its traditional energy-mineral base. This sector has gone international and maintains its economic primacy (23% of GDP and 60% of exports). However, extractive industries are exhausting subsurface resources after several failed attempts at diversification. For all these reasons, the global crisis has impacted South Africa more severely than other similar economies. There has been a level of capital flight in a situation marked by rising social tensions and the massacre of mine workers, which recalled the terrible repression of the past.

Turkey

The case of Turkey also illustrates how a regional sub-power can stand out, based on its geopolitical military weight. Over the last few decades, the dominant classes there have developed a strategy for expansion into the Arab world and the Mediterranean. This policy is based on deploying its military beyond its borders (the occupation of Cyprus) and in reinforcing its internal oppression of the Kurdish minority. The national rights of this section of the population are put down at the point of a gun, disregarding the opinion of the majority of the Turkish people. But after 30 years of resistance, the government had to accept the opening of negotiations when faced with the establishment of Kurdish autonomous regions in Iraq and Syria.[20]